



FIELD AND SIEGE ARTILLERY (1650–1780)

Different types of artillery had become well-established by the mid-17th century. Field artillery was portable, and was towed into battle alongside infantry and cavalry. These guns were known as 6-, 9-, and 12-pounders, referring to the weight of the iron balls they fired. Siege artillery was composed of 18-pounders and even heavier guns, designed to break down fortifications. Mortars, short-barreled guns set at a high angle of elevation for use during sieges, had also been developed. Most large cannons were muzzle-loading. Cannon made of wrought iron were rarely being built, as guns could now be made more cheaply and quickly from cast iron, which had recently been perfected.



▲ INDIAN 6-POUNDER

Date 1693–1743

Origin India

Length 12½ft (3.86m)

Caliber 3.74in (95mm)

Like many artillery pieces of the time, this gun is described by the weight of its ammunition—6-lb (2.72-kg) iron balls. The caliber of such weapons is based on the diameter of the shot they fired. The 6-pounder's cast bronze barrel has a bore lined with strips of iron, to make it more durable.



Decoration molded in relief

Cascabel to secure cannon with ropes for managing recoil when it is fired

▲ SINHALESE BRONZE GUN

Date 1699

Origin Ceylon (modern-day Sri Lanka)

Length 4ft (1.19m)

Caliber 2.1in (53.3mm)

This small field gun is decorated with bands of stylized foliage and has the badge of the Dutch East India Company. The name Jaffanapatnam (a town in northern Ceylon) is written around the breech.



Third barrel sits on top of the other two

Relief decoration includes scrolls

Trunnion

▲ BRONZE THREE-BARRELED GUN

Date 1704

Origin France

Length 5¼ft (1.62m)

Caliber .04in (1.15mm)

Three barrels, two side by side with the third above, were cast in one piece and could be fired one at a time or simultaneously. The intriguing design did not prove successful in practice, because this field gun was difficult to reload and very heavy to maneuver.



Monogram of King George I

Wooden bed



Highly ornate cast barrel

Spokes carved as flames from the Sun

Studded iron tires

◀ COEHORN MORTAR

Date c.1720

Origin England

Length 1ft (0.32m)

Caliber 4.5in (114.3mm)

The Coehorn Mortar was a small, portable mortar used to despatch grenades. Swiss-born Andrew Schalch, first Master Founder of the Royal Brass Foundry at Woolwich in England, cast this one. It is mounted on its original wooden bed, which is just 12in (30cm) wide and 20in (51cm) long.